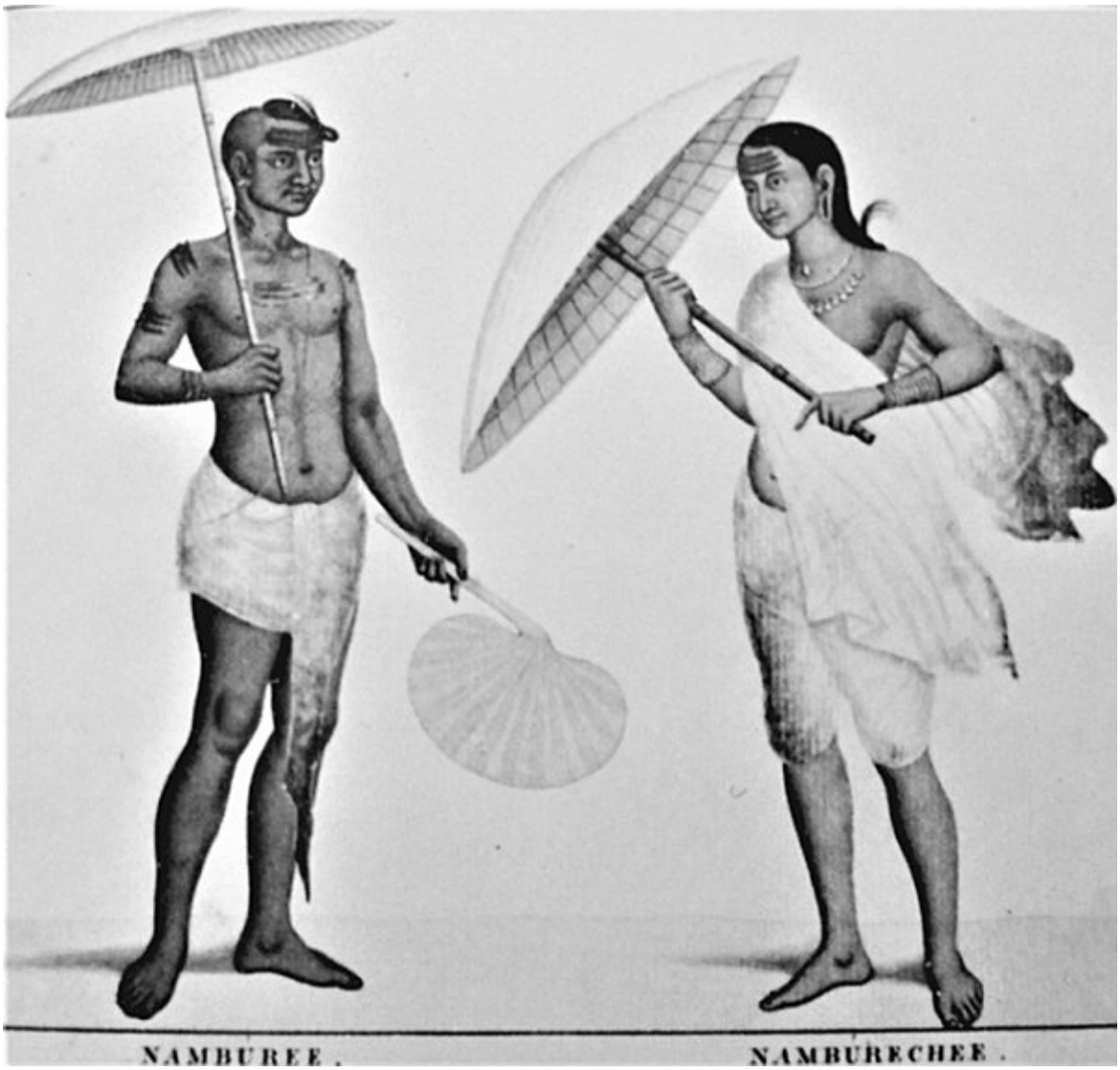


‘Namburee and Namburechee’: a Nambudiri Brahmin and his wife, one of thirteen watercolours of castes of the Malabar coast, c. 1828.

The kingdom of Travancore was largely the creation of one man. When in 1729 twenty-three-year-old Raja Marthanda Varma ascended the royal *gadi* of the ancient coastal kingdom of Venad – afterwards Quilon – he was expected to rule as a mere figurehead, the real power being shared between a group of Nair nobles known as the Ettuveetil Pillamar or the ‘Lords of the Eight Houses’, and the Nambudiri Ettara Yogam, the ‘Council of Eight and a Half’, which managed the enormously wealthy and powerful